THE DEAD DON'T FORGET

The Complete Scripts

Episodes 1–3

by Maya Clark

Every word. Exactly as written.

THE DEAD DON'T FORGET — Episode 1: "The Man at the Gate"

Full script (Maya's original — use word for word)

The first thing Daniel Vale noticed was that the man outside the gate wasn't trying to get in.

That was wrong.

Everybody tried to get in.

That was the rule now.

Hungry people tried to get in.

Armed people tried to get in.

Sick people tried to get in.

People pretending not to be sick tried to get in.

Children tried to get in.

Thieves tried to get in.

Mothers carrying children tried to get in.

Men carrying guns tried to get in.

People who had spent three weeks alone in houses with no electricity and no food tried to get in.

Sometimes they begged.

Sometimes they lied.

Sometimes they threatened.

Once, three men had stood outside the western gate for almost six hours claiming they were federal contractors.

Daniel had asked what agency.

They couldn't agree.

One said FEMA.

One said Homeland Security.

The third said they were from the Department of Transportation.

Daniel had laughed.

Then he'd ordered the guards to fire warning shots.

They left.

That was how the world worked now.

The desperate came to the gate.

They wanted something.

Food.

Water.

Medicine.

Safety.

The dead wanted something too.

But Daniel didn't know that yet.

He stood in the warehouse office with a paper cup of coffee in one hand and a pistol in the other.

The coffee was cold.

He drank it anyway.

On the wall beside him hung a whiteboard.

Names covered it.

One hundred forty-three survivors.

Every person inside the warehouse had been assigned a number.

Not because Daniel didn't know their names.

Because numbers were easier.

Numbers didn't argue.

Numbers didn't get offended.

Numbers didn't ask why their neighbor received antibiotics while their own child didn't.

Numbers could be moved.

Transferred.

Crossed out.

Daniel stared at the board.

Someone had added another name.

He hadn't authorized it.

MELISSA HARPER — 144

Daniel turned.

The door opened.

Mara stood there.

She had blood on her scrubs.

Daniel's eyes went immediately to it.

"Yours?"

"No."

"Whose?"

"A boy."

"How bad?"

"He'll live."

Daniel nodded.

That was supposed to be good news.

Mara didn't smile.

"There's someone at the gate."

"I know."

"You've been watching?"

"Three minutes."

"How long has he been there?"

"Nine."

Mara looked through the dirty office window.

The warehouse lights flickered.

The backup generator coughed somewhere below them.

Outside, beyond the welded steel barricade and the stacked shipping containers, a figure stood in the road.

A man.

Or what used to be one.

He wore a gray maintenance uniform.

One sleeve was torn.

His head leaned slightly to the right.

His face was pale enough to look almost blue beneath the moonlight.

He wasn't moving.

Mara whispered, "Is he infected?"

Daniel didn't answer.

She looked at him.

"That's not what I asked."

"I know."

"Then answer."

Daniel put down his coffee.

"He's dead."

The radio on the desk crackled.

A guard spoke.

"Mr. Vale?"

Daniel picked it up.

"Go."

"He's still standing there."

"I can see him."

"Should we shoot?"

Daniel watched the figure.

"Wait."

A pause.

"Sir?"

"I said wait."

Mara stared at him.

"You don't know what it is."

"I know exactly what it is."

"No. You don't."

Daniel looked at her.

She wasn't frightened.

That was what worried him.

Fear made people predictable.

Mara was angry.

Angry people did stupid things.

"Get back inside," he said.

"No."

"Mara."

"You've been telling everyone else to stay inside for weeks."

"Because they're not doctors."

"I'm not talking about the gate."

Daniel looked at her.

She took a step toward him.

"You're getting worse."

"I'm tired."

"You haven't slept."

"I'm running a settlement."

"You're drinking more."

"There's no law against it."

"There doesn't have to be."

He looked away.

Mara's voice softened.

"How long since you spoke to Mom?"

Daniel didn't answer.

"Exactly."

"Mara."

"She thinks you're dead."

"That's convenient."

"She thinks you chose not to call."

Daniel's jaw tightened.

"I tried."

"Once."

"Three times."

"Three times?"

"Three times."

"And?"

"No answer."

Mara looked toward the gate.

Then back at him.

"You know what I think?"

"I rarely enjoy that sentence."

"I think you're relieved she didn't answer."

Daniel's face changed.

Only slightly.

But Mara noticed.

She always noticed.

Before the world ended, she'd spent years reading sick people.

She'd learned that the body confessed before the mouth did.

Daniel was confessing now.

Outside, something struck the gate.

Everyone froze.

Once.

A dull metallic boom.

Then silence.

Another.

Boom.

Boom.

The radio erupted.

"He's walking toward it."

Daniel picked it up.

"Nobody opens the gate."

"We weren't—"

"Nobody opens it."

The guard's voice trembled.

"Sir, he's looking at us."

Daniel walked toward the window.

The figure had moved.

Slowly.

Barely.

But it had moved.

Twenty feet closer.

Its face was visible now.

Daniel stared.

The room seemed to shrink around him.

Mara noticed.

"What?"

He didn't answer.

"Daniel."

The dead man lifted his head.

Moonlight caught his eyes.

Daniel's hand tightened around the pistol.

Mara stepped beside him.

"Do you know him?"

"No."

The dead man smiled.

It was a terrible thing.

Not because it was monstrous.

Because it was familiar.

Daniel had seen that smile before.

In photographs.

At dinner tables.

Across conference rooms.

On courthouse steps.

He had seen it in people who had just lost something and were trying not to let anyone see how badly it hurt.

The dead man lifted one hand.

His index finger pointed through the gate.

Directly at Daniel.

Mara whispered:

"Who is he?"

Daniel didn't breathe.

The man opened his mouth.

His voice was ruined.

Dry.

Almost too quiet to hear.

But the speakers around the gate carried it.

Everyone inside the warehouse heard the words.

"You remember me."

Daniel stepped backward.

Mara looked at him.

The dead man continued.

"You told me nobody would care."

Daniel's pistol lowered.

"No."

Mara's face changed.

"Daniel?"

The dead man's smile disappeared.

"You said I had no one."

Daniel whispered:

"Elias."

The warehouse went silent.

The name meant nothing to most of them.

But it meant everything to Daniel.

Elias Mercer.

Apartment 3B.

Cincinnati.

Maintenance supervisor.

Wife named Ruth.

Son named Caleb.

One unpaid mortgage.

Three months behind.

A bad back.

A disciplinary warning.

A building scheduled for demolition.

Daniel remembered the file.

He remembered the meeting.

He remembered Elias sitting across from him.

He remembered the man's hands.

That was the strange thing.

Daniel remembered his hands.

Not his face.

Not his voice.

His hands.

Large.

Calloused.

Resting on the table.

Elias had asked him one question.

"Is there anything I can do?"

Daniel had said no.

That wasn't true.

There had been something he could do.

Daniel could have stopped the eviction.

Could have found another building.

Could have refused the contract.

Could have walked away.

Instead, he'd signed another document.

And three months later Elias was dead.

Daniel had never attended the funeral.

Now Elias stood outside his gate.

Dead.

Waiting.

Mara stared at her father.

"You knew him."

Daniel didn't answer.

"You knew him."

"Yes."

"What did you do?"

Daniel looked through the window.

Elias hadn't moved.

Then Daniel noticed something.

There were others behind him.

At first he thought they were shadows.

Then one moved.

Another appeared.

Then another.

Mara whispered:

"Oh God."

Daniel counted.

Seven.

No.

Eleven.

No.

More.

Figures emerged from the darkness along the road.

All walking in the same direction.

Toward the warehouse.

Toward him.

The radio screamed.

"Mr. Vale!"

Daniel grabbed it.

"How many?"

"We can't count them."

"Open the south cameras."

"They're already on."

"Switch to infrared."

"We did."

"And?"

The guard's voice cracked.

"Sir..."

"What?"

"They're all looking at the warehouse."

Daniel closed his eyes.

The dead outside didn't rush.

They didn't pound against the fence.

They didn't scream.

They simply stood there.

Waiting.

Mara turned toward him.

"What did you do?"

Daniel didn't answer.

She grabbed his arm.

"What did you do?"

He pulled away.

"Get the medical team ready."

"Daniel—"

"Get everyone into the interior rooms."

"Why?"

"Because we're going to have a breach."

The words had barely left his mouth when the warehouse lights went out.

Darkness swallowed everything.

Somewhere below them, people screamed.

Daniel drew his pistol.

The emergency lights flickered red.

Mara whispered his name.

Daniel listened.

From outside came the sound of dozens of feet moving across concrete.

Slow.

Patient.

Unhurried.

Then the radio came alive.

A guard was screaming.

"They're at the eastern gate!"

Daniel ran.

Mara followed.

They reached the catwalk overlooking the main warehouse floor.

People were flooding toward the interior barricades.

Children crying.

Adults shouting.

Guards trying to organize them.

Daniel raised his voice.

"EVERYONE TO THE INNER WALL!"

The crowd began moving.

Then a gunshot cracked.

Someone fell.

Panic exploded.

Daniel pushed through the crowd.

"WHO FIRED?"

Nobody answered.

Another shot.

Daniel turned.

One of the guards stood near the eastern loading entrance.

His rifle was raised.

His face was white.

"Open the gate," someone shouted.

Daniel stared at him.

"Don't."

"They're coming through!"

"Hold it."

"We can't!"

"Hold it!"

The guard looked at him.

Then at the crowd.

Then back at the gate.

Something slammed against the other side.

The entire metal door shook.

The crowd screamed.

Daniel saw Mara.

She was helping a little girl behind the barricade.

He saw the child's mother.

Then he saw something else.

A face through the narrow reinforced window.

Elias.

Daniel stared at him.

Elias stared back.

And behind him stood dozens of dead people.

But Elias wasn't looking at the guards.

He wasn't looking at the door.

He was looking only at Daniel.

Then he lifted his hand.

And pointed toward the whiteboard.

Daniel's stomach dropped.

The office was fifty feet away.

The whiteboard was visible through the glass.

Names.

Numbers.

Lives.

Daniel suddenly understood.

The dead weren't attacking the warehouse.

They were following a list.

His list.

He turned toward the board.

Melissa Harper.

Number 144.

Daniel stared.

He had added her name himself.

That morning.

A woman whose husband had died three days earlier.

A woman whose ration card Daniel had almost revoked because she'd accused him of stealing antibiotics.

A woman who had told him that everyone inside the warehouse was becoming afraid of him.

Daniel had thought nothing of it.

Now her name sat beneath the others.

And beneath it, someone had written another name.

In handwriting Daniel didn't recognize.

DANIEL VALE — 000

Mara saw it too.

"What does that mean?"

Daniel couldn't speak.

The eastern gate began to bend inward.

Once.

Twice.

Then the metal screamed.

The guards raised their weapons.

Daniel looked at the dead outside.

For the first time since the collapse began, he felt something stronger than fear.

Recognition.

Not of Elias.

Not of the others.

Of himself.

He understood what was happening.

And he understood why they had come.

The dead had not forgotten.

They had simply been waiting.

The gate buckled.

Mara grabbed his arm.

"Dad."

Daniel looked at her.

"What?"

She pointed toward the road.

More figures were emerging from the darkness.

Dozens.

Then hundreds.

And among them, Daniel recognized another face.

A woman.

Old.

Gray-haired.

Wearing a blue city sanitation uniform.

Daniel knew her.

He had destroyed her pension.

Another figure walked beside her.

A teenage boy.

Daniel didn't recognize him.

Yet.

The boy stopped.

Turned his head.

And looked directly at Daniel.

Mara whispered:

"Who are they?"

Daniel couldn't answer.

Because he had finally realized the worst part.

The dead weren't coming for the warehouse.

They weren't coming for food.

They weren't coming for blood.

They were coming for him.

And there were enough of them to fill the entire road.

The eastern gate finally gave way.

Daniel raised his pistol.

Outside, Elias Mercer took one slow step forward.

And smiled.

Episode 2 — "The Names On The Wall"

The eastern gate came down with a sound Daniel would remember for the rest of his life.

Not the crash.

Not the gunfire.

Not the screaming.

The sound that stayed with him was the final metallic shriek of the hinges tearing loose, because it sounded almost human.

Like something screaming for mercy.

Then the dead came through.

Daniel raised his pistol.

"Hold your fire!"

Nobody listened.

The warehouse erupted.

Gunshots hammered the concrete walls. Muzzle flashes strobed through the darkness. People screamed and ducked behind pallets, machinery, shelving, anything that looked solid enough to stop a body.

The emergency lights painted everything red.

Red faces.

Red walls.

Red hands.

Red blood.

Daniel saw a guard empty half a magazine into a woman wearing a blue sanitation uniform.

She kept walking.

"Stop shooting!"

The guard fired again.

The woman didn't fall.

She was already dead.

Daniel knew that.

Everybody knew that.

But knowing something and believing it were two different things.

The woman walked between the bullets.

One struck her cheek.

Another tore through her shoulder.

She didn't even blink.

Then she reached the guard.

He dropped his rifle.

"No."

The woman stopped inches from him.

Her mouth moved.

Daniel couldn't hear what she said.

The guard stumbled backward.

"Please."

She touched his face.

He screamed.

Daniel shoved through the crowd.

"Mara!"

"Here!"

He saw his daughter kneeling beside the little girl.

"Get her inside!"

"She's terrified!"

"Get her inside!"

Mara looked toward the breach.

There were too many.

"Daniel, we can't hold this."

"I know."

"Then what are you doing?"

Daniel looked around.

His brain did what it had always done when disaster arrived.

It sorted.

Threats.

Resources.

Exits.

People.

Weak points.

He saw the forklift bay.

The overhead crane.

The loading platforms.

The interior steel doors.

The emergency sprinkler system.

The fuel tanks.

The generator room.

He saw possibilities.

He had spent twenty years finding exits other people couldn't see.

But this wasn't a negotiation.

There was no judge to bribe.

No inspector to intimidate.

No executive who could be bought.

There was no person on the other side of the problem.

There was only the dead.

And the dead didn't negotiate.

"Daniel!"

Mara grabbed his shoulder.

He looked at her.

She was crying.

He hadn't noticed.

That frightened him more than the zombies.

Mara Vale almost never cried.

"Tell me what to do."

Daniel stared at her.

For half a second, he saw her as a little girl again.

Eight years old.

Sitting on the kitchen counter.

Swinging her legs.

Asking him why he worked so late.

He had told her he was making sure people were safe.

She had believed him.

That memory hurt.

He pushed it away.

"Take the children to the machine room."

"What about everyone else?"

"I'll handle it."

"No."

"Mara."

"No."

A dead man stumbled through the broken gate.

Daniel raised his gun.

The man stopped.

Daniel recognized him.

He had never met him.

But he knew the face.

A photograph.

A newspaper article.

A name on an old report.

Daniel's stomach tightened.

The dead man pointed at him.

"You signed it."

Daniel fired.

The bullet struck the dead man's chest.

He fell.

The crowd went silent.

Then the body moved.

Daniel's gun suddenly felt very small.

The dead man pushed himself upright.

Someone whispered:

"What the hell are these things?"

Daniel backed away.

The dead man pointed again.

"You signed it."

He started walking.

Daniel fired again.

The body dropped.

This time it stayed down.

For three seconds.

Then it rose again.

Daniel heard someone behind him say:

"That's impossible."

He thought:

No.

It's worse than impossible.

It's personal.

Mara dragged the little girl toward the interior corridor.

"Come on."

The child wouldn't move.

"My mom."

Mara looked toward the warehouse floor.

"Where is she?"

The girl pointed.

Mara followed her finger.

A woman lay beneath a pallet.

Dead.

The child screamed.

Mara crouched.

"Listen to me."

The girl shook her head.

"She's dead."

"I know."

"We have to go."

"That's my mom."

"I know."

"You can't leave her."

Mara looked at the woman's body.

Then at the dead pouring through the gate.

Her medical instincts told her the truth immediately.

There was nothing she could do.

Her human instincts refused to accept it.

She picked up the child.

The girl fought her.

"My mom!"

Mara held her tighter.

"I'm sorry."

She carried her away.

Behind them, Daniel heard another scream.

He turned.

The woman beneath the pallet had moved.

Her eyes opened.

The dead mother sat upright.

The child saw her.

"MOM!"

Mara froze.

Daniel shouted:

"Don't let her go!"

Too late.

The child tore herself free.

She ran.

"MOM!"

The dead woman looked up.

Her face was gray.

Her lips moved.

"Emily."

The child stopped.

Mara stared.

Daniel stared.

The woman reached for her daughter.

Emily ran into her arms.

The dead woman held her.

Then whispered:

"I'm sorry."

The entire warehouse went silent.

The dead woman collapsed.

Emily screamed.

Mara rushed forward.

Daniel stood frozen.

That wasn't how the others behaved.

That wasn't what the stories had said.

The dead were supposed to attack.

They were supposed to bite.

They were supposed to kill.

But this woman had recognized her daughter.

She had remembered her.

And for one brief moment, the thing inside the corpse had seemed almost human.

Mara looked at Daniel.

"Did you know they could do that?"

"No."

"You're lying."

"No."

"You don't know anything, do you?"

Daniel looked toward the breach.

Elias Mercer stood among the dead.

Watching.

Waiting.

Then Daniel saw something hanging from Elias's hand.

A piece of paper.

Daniel stared.

It was folded in half.

Elias lifted it.

Daniel knew that paper.

He had seen it twelve years ago.

A property transfer agreement.

The document that had started the chain of events that destroyed Elias's life.

Daniel's heart began beating faster.

He stepped toward him.

Elias raised the paper.

Then dropped it.

It landed on the concrete.

Daniel didn't move.

Mara did.

She picked it up.

Her eyes moved across the page.

Then stopped.

She looked at her father.

"What is this?"

Daniel didn't answer.

"Daniel."

"Give me that."

She didn't.

Her eyes kept reading.

"What is Mercer Development?"

"Give me the paper."

"You told me you worked in consulting."

"I did."

"This says you represented Mercer Development."

"I did."

"And this?"

She turned the page.

Daniel's silence answered her.

Mara looked at the signature.

His signature.

"You evicted them."

"It was legal."

Her expression changed.

"That's your answer?"

"They had been notified."

"You evicted a family."

"Several families."

"How many?"

Daniel looked away.

"How many?"

"I don't remember."

"You remember."

He didn't answer.

Mara's voice dropped.

"You remember everything."

Daniel looked at her.

She was holding the document like it was contaminated.

"Is that why they're here?"

Daniel stared at the dead.

Elias took another step.

Then another.

The dead behind him followed.

Daniel suddenly understood something.

They weren't moving toward everyone.

They were moving around people.

They were avoiding survivors.

They were navigating.

Searching.

Tracking.

One by one, they were approaching Daniel.

Not the others.

Him.

Mara stepped backward.

"How many people did you hurt?"

Daniel swallowed.

"I don't know."

"How many?"

"Enough."

She looked at the paper.

Then at Elias.

"Tell me."

Daniel's eyes hardened.

"Not here."

"Why not?"

"Because we have a bigger problem."

"No."

Mara shook her head.

"We have exactly the problem you created."

A gunshot cracked.

Daniel turned.

One of the guards had shot another survivor.

The man fell.

"Why did you do that?"

The guard screamed:

"He was bitten!"

Everyone looked at the body.

A bite mark showed through the man's sleeve.

The warehouse erupted again.

People backed away.

Some raised weapons.

Others shouted.

The guard aimed his rifle.

"We can't take chances!"

Daniel saw the fear.

He understood it.

Fear was contagious.

More contagious than anything the dead carried.

If panic spread, the warehouse would destroy itself.

Daniel climbed onto a loading platform.

"EVERYBODY STOP!"

Nobody stopped.

He fired one shot into the ceiling.

The echo silenced them.

"Put the weapons down."

The guard shook his head.

"He was bitten."

"I said put it down."

"What if he turns?"

"Then I'll deal with it."

"You don't know that."

Daniel stepped toward him.

"I know exactly what happens when frightened people start shooting each other."

The guard lowered his rifle.

Daniel looked at the wounded man.

"Get him to medical."

Mara stared at him.

"You just said—"

"I know what I said."

The dead continued moving through the warehouse.

None attacked.

None bit.

They simply walked.

Toward Daniel.

The interior doors finally closed.

Steel slammed against steel.

The survivors were trapped inside the machine room.

One hundred forty-three people had become one hundred forty-one.

Two dead.

Three wounded.

Twenty-seven children.

One generator.

Less than two days of clean water.

Four days of food if rations were cut again.

And somewhere beyond the doors, the dead were waiting.

Daniel stood over the emergency operations table.

Mara entered.

She shut the door behind her.

"You lied."

Daniel didn't look up.

"I've lied about a lot of things."

"You knew that name."

"Elias?"

"Yes."

"I told you."

"You told me nothing."

Daniel stared at the map.

"The people outside aren't random."

"I know."

"They're people you've harmed."

"I know."

"How many?"

Daniel rubbed his eyes.

"Probably more than you want to hear."

Mara stepped closer.

"Then I'm going to hear it."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because it doesn't help."

"It helps me."

"You're angry."

"Yes."

"Good."

She stopped.

Daniel finally looked at her.

"Stay angry."

"What?"

"Anger keeps you alive."

"You've built your whole life around that."

"Maybe."

"No."

She pointed at him.

"You built this place the same way you built everything else."

Daniel said nothing.

"You find something people need."

She took another step.

"Then you make sure they can't get it without you."

Another.

"You control the water."

Another.

"The food."

Another.

"The guns."

Another.

"Information."

Daniel's jaw tightened.

Mara's voice cracked.

"And you call it protecting people."

Daniel looked at the floor.

"You think I don't know what I am?"

"I think you know exactly what you are."

She paused.

"I think that's why you're afraid."

Daniel looked up.

"Of what?"

She answered quietly.

"That they're right."

The room fell silent.

A radio crackled.

A voice whispered:

"Mr. Vale?"

Daniel picked it up.

"What?"

"There's someone at the north door."

"One of ours?"

"No."

"Dead?"

"We don't know."

Daniel looked at Mara.

"Who is it?"

The guard hesitated.

"She says she knows you."

Daniel's stomach tightened.

"What's her name?"

A long pause.

Then:

"Lena."

Daniel stopped breathing.

Mara noticed.

"Who is Lena?"

Daniel didn't answer.

The guard continued.

"She says her last name is Mercer."

Mara looked at her father.

Daniel stared at the radio.

Outside, somewhere beyond the steel doors, the dead began pounding.

Not violently.

Not desperately.

One knock at a time.

Slow.

Deliberate.

Almost polite.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Daniel closed his eyes.

He knew that name.

Lena Mercer.

Elias's daughter.

He remembered her.

She had been sixteen.

She had stood behind her father during the eviction.

Daniel remembered her eyes.

He remembered the hatred.

He remembered telling security to remove her.

He remembered her screaming.

He remembered the last thing she had said to him.

"Someday you're going to need somebody, and nobody's going to help you."

Daniel opened his eyes.

Mara was watching him.

"She's alive?"

Daniel didn't answer.

"You're afraid of her."

"No."

"You are."

Daniel walked toward the radio.

"Bring her in."

Mara grabbed his arm.

"No."

Daniel looked at her.

"She may know what's happening."

"She may want you dead."

"Then she gets in line."

Mara stared at him.

"You're going to let her inside?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Daniel looked toward the steel door.

"Because she's the first person who might know why the dead are here."

The north door opened at 2:17 in the morning.

Daniel stood behind the barricade.

Three guards aimed their weapons.

Mara stood beside him.

The door opened six inches.

A woman stepped through.

She was thinner than Daniel remembered.

Much thinner.

Her hair was cut short.

She wore a dark coat and carried a backpack.

There was a rifle strapped across her back.

A knife at her belt.

She looked older than thirty.

But her eyes were exactly the same.

Daniel knew those eyes.

Lena Mercer stopped.

She looked at the guards.

Then at Mara.

Then at Daniel.

Her expression didn't change.

Daniel said her name.

"Lena."

She smiled.

Not warmly.

Not cruelly.

Just knowingly.

"You remember."

Daniel felt something cold move through his chest.

She stepped closer.

"Of course you remember."

Mara looked between them.

"You know my father?"

Lena laughed.

"Your father?"

She looked at Daniel.

Then back at Mara.

"That's what he calls himself now?"

Daniel said nothing.

Lena removed the rifle from her shoulder.

Every guard raised his weapon.

She set the rifle on the ground.

Then the backpack.

Then the knife.

"I didn't come here to kill him."

Mara asked:

"Why did you come?"

Lena looked toward the sealed eastern doors.

The pounding had stopped.

She whispered:

"Because you're all going to die."

Nobody spoke.

Lena looked directly at Daniel.

"Not because they're going to eat you."

She pointed toward the doors.

"They don't want your flesh."

Daniel swallowed.

"What do they want?"

Lena's eyes hardened.

"They want you to remember."

Daniel stared at her.

"Remember what?"

Lena stepped closer.

"Everything."

Then she reached into her coat.

Daniel's hand went toward his pistol.

She pulled out a small cassette recorder.

Old.

Black.

Scratched.

She placed it on the table.

"I found this in my father's apartment."

Daniel stared at it.

"He recorded everything."

Lena pressed PLAY.

Static filled the room.

Then a man's voice.

Weak.

Tired.

Terrified.

Elias.

Daniel recognized him immediately.

The recording began with a date.

Twelve years earlier.

Then Elias said:

"If you're hearing this, Daniel Vale was wrong."

Daniel's face went pale.

Lena watched him.

The recording continued.

"He thinks this is about money."

Static.

A breath.

Then:

"It isn't."

Daniel stepped backward.

Mara looked at him.

Elias's voice returned.

"The company didn't just buy the buildings."

Daniel froze.

"They bought the people."

The recording clicked.

Stopped.

Everyone in the room stared at the machine.

Daniel whispered:

"What does that mean?"

Lena looked at him.

"I don't know."

She pressed PLAY again.

The tape continued.

Elias's breathing was faster now.

"There are names."

A pause.

"Thousands of them."

Daniel felt the room tilt.

"People who were moved."

Static.

"People who disappeared."

Another pause.

"People who died."

Daniel looked toward the door.

Something scratched against the other side.

Lena whispered:

"My father believed the outbreak isn't creating memories."

Daniel turned.

"Then what is it doing?"

She looked at him.

"It is collecting them."

The scratching stopped.

Everyone waited.

Then something spoke through the steel.

A man's voice.

Quiet.

Close.

Impossible.

Daniel knew it.

It belonged to someone who had been dead for twelve years.

"Daniel."

Mara's face went white.

The voice continued.

"You forgot me."

Daniel stared at the door.

Lena whispered:

"Who is that?"

Daniel couldn't answer.

Because he knew the voice.

He had heard it once.

Only once.

During a meeting twelve years earlier.

A man who had signed a contract.

A man Daniel had paid to disappear.

A man whose name had never appeared in any newspaper.

A man Daniel had spent twelve years convincing himself had never existed.

The voice came again.

"Daniel Vale."

The lights flickered.

The generator coughed.

And somewhere inside the warehouse, the whiteboard fell from the wall.

The sound echoed through the building.

Mara turned toward the hallway.

Daniel didn't move.

Lena picked up her rifle.

"What happens now?" Mara asked.

Daniel stared at the steel door.

He finally answered.

"Now we find out how many names I buried."

Outside, something began laughing.

And beneath the laughter, dozens of dead voices spoke together.

Not screaming.

Not threatening.

Remembering.

"Daniel Vale."

The emergency lights went out

THE DEAD DON'T FORGET — Episode 3: "The Ledger"

At 2:19 in the morning, the warehouse went completely dark.

For three seconds, nobody moved.

Daniel counted them.

One.

Two.

Three.

Then the emergency generator coughed back to life.

The red lights returned.

Dimmer this time.

Unsteady.

The warehouse looked different under them.

Less like a shelter.

More like a crime scene.

Daniel stood beside the operations table, staring at the cassette recorder.

Lena Mercer stood across from him.

Mara was between them.

Neither woman trusted him.

Daniel couldn't blame them.

The dead were outside.

The living were inside.

And somehow Daniel was more frightened of the second group.

He picked up the recorder.

"Where did you find this?"

Lena didn't answer.

Daniel looked at her.

"Where?"

"My father's apartment."

"That's been abandoned for years."

"I know."

"How did you get inside?"

"I've been inside a lot of places."

"That isn't an answer."

"It's the one you're getting."

Daniel studied her.

Same eyes.

Same stubbornness.

Different person.

The sixteen-year-old girl he'd ordered removed from her home was gone.

In her place stood someone who had learned how to survive without asking permission.

Daniel set the recorder down.

"Play it again."

Lena didn't move.

"Again."

"No."

Daniel's expression hardened.

"You came here because you wanted something."

"I came here because I wanted you to hear it."

"I heard it."

"No."

She stepped closer.

"You heard the words."

Her eyes moved toward the eastern doors.

"You didn't hear the warning."

Daniel's jaw tightened.

"What warning?"

Lena looked at Mara.

"Your father knows how to make people disappear."

Mara's face changed.

"I know."

Lena looked back at Daniel.

"He just doesn't know how to make them stay gone."

A pounding came from somewhere in the warehouse.

Everyone turned.

Not the eastern gate.

Not the northern door.

Inside.

Daniel reached for his pistol.

"Where?"

The radio crackled.

"Mr. Vale?"

"Go."

"Movement in Sector Four."

"How many?"

"One."

"Identify."

"We can't."

"Why?"

"Because the cameras aren't working."

Daniel looked at the control board.

Half the indicators were dark.

He turned to the guards.

"Lock down Sector Four."

A voice came through the radio.

"Already did."

Daniel frowned.

"Then how is something moving?"

Silence.

Daniel's eyes narrowed.

"Open the camera feed manually."

"Trying."

A screen flickered.

Static.

Then an image appeared.

A hallway.

Empty.

Concrete floor.

Steel walls.

A dead fluorescent tube hanging from the ceiling.

Daniel watched.

Nothing.

Then a figure crossed the far end of the corridor.

Daniel leaned closer.

"Rewind."

The guard did.

The figure crossed again.

"Freeze."

The image stopped.

Daniel stared.

Mara came beside him.

"What is it?"

Daniel zoomed the image.

The figure wore a warehouse security uniform.

One of their own.

"Who is that?"

Nobody answered.

Daniel looked at the guards.

"Who is missing?"

A guard checked the roster.

"Nobody."

"Check again."

The guard's fingers moved.

Then stopped.

"Sir..."

"What?"

"We have one unaccounted for."

"Name?"

The guard swallowed.

"Thomas Redd."

Daniel knew him.

Everyone did.

Thomas had worked security for three weeks.

Quiet.

Reliable.

Never caused trouble.

Daniel looked at the screen.

"Where was he assigned?"

"South corridor."

"He's dead?"

"We don't know."

Daniel stared at the frozen image.

The figure had stopped beneath the light.

Its face was hidden in shadow.

Then the screen flickered.

The figure turned.

Daniel saw its face.

Thomas Redd.

Except Thomas was smiling.

The radio crackled.

A voice whispered:

"Mr. Vale?"

Daniel grabbed it.

"Thomas?"

The voice laughed.

"No."

Daniel froze.

The voice continued.

"You know me."

The line went dead.

Mara looked at him.

"Who was it?"

Daniel didn't answer.

Lena did.

"Another name."

Daniel looked at her.

She picked up her rifle.

"That's what you're going to find."

They moved through the warehouse in four-person teams.

Daniel hated the arrangement.

Too many people.

Too much noise.

Too much chance for panic.

But he couldn't go alone.

Mara refused to stay behind.

Lena refused to let Daniel out of her sight.

And two guards, Curtis and Ben, insisted on coming.

They reached Sector Four.

The corridor was empty.

Daniel raised his flashlight.

The beam moved across the walls.

Nothing.

No blood.

No body.

No footprints.

Curtis whispered:

"Maybe he left."

Daniel shook his head.

"The doors are locked."

"Could he have climbed through the ventilation?"

"No."

"How do you know?"

"Because I designed the vents."

Curtis gave him a strange look.

Daniel ignored it.

He crouched.

There was something on the floor.

Paper.

A single sheet.

He picked it up.

It was old.

Yellowed.

Folded several times.

A name was written across the top.

JONAH BELL.

Daniel's hand stopped.

Lena saw his face.

"Who?"

Daniel folded the paper.

"Nobody."

She stared at him.

"You said that too quickly."

Daniel put the paper in his pocket.

"Move."

They continued.

Twenty feet farther down the corridor, they found Thomas.

Or what was left of him.

He was sitting against the wall.

His uniform was soaked with blood.

His eyes were open.

His throat had been cut.

Mara moved toward him.

Daniel caught her arm.

"Don't."

"I'm a nurse."

"He's dead."

"I know."

She pulled free.

She crouched beside the body.

"He's been dead for hours."

Curtis looked around.

"Then who was on the camera?"

Nobody answered.

Lena knelt beside Thomas.

She examined his hands.

"Look."

Daniel crouched.

There was ink on Thomas's palm.

A name.

Written in shaky black letters.

JONAH BELL.

Daniel stood.

Lena looked up.

"You know him."

Daniel didn't answer.

Mara stood.

"Who is Jonah Bell?"

Daniel stared at the name.

Then said:

"An accountant."

"From where?"

"My office."

"When?"

"Years ago."

"What happened to him?"

Daniel looked at Thomas's body.

"He disappeared."

Lena's voice was quiet.

"People don't disappear."

Daniel looked at her.

"Sometimes they do."

"No."

She stood.

"Sometimes someone makes them disappear."

Daniel's eyes hardened.

"Careful."

"Why?"

"Because you don't know what you're talking about."

"I know exactly what I'm talking about."

She pointed at the body.

"The dead are telling us."

Daniel looked at Thomas.

Then at the name.

Something inside him shifted.

Not guilt.

Not yet.

Recognition.

He remembered Jonah.

A thin man.

Glasses.

Always carrying a blue notebook.

Jonah had worked for Daniel for four years.

He had been good at numbers.

Too good.

Jonah discovered discrepancies in one of Daniel's biggest accounts.

Money moving through shell companies.

Payments to inspectors.

Cash transfers.

Settlement agreements.

Bribes.

Daniel had told Jonah to forget what he'd seen.

Jonah hadn't.

So Daniel had called someone.

Three days later Jonah stopped coming to work.

Daniel had never asked where he went.

He didn't need to.

That's how the system worked.

You didn't ask questions if you already knew the answer.

Daniel walked away from Thomas's body.

Mara followed.

"Where are you going?"

"Office."

"Why?"

"I need something."

"What?"

Daniel stopped.

"My old files."

Lena laughed bitterly.

"Of course."

Daniel turned.

"What?"

"You kept them."

"Kept what?"

"Everything."

Daniel said nothing.

Lena stepped closer.

"You told my father paperwork didn't matter."

"I never said that."

"You told him his lease meant nothing."

Daniel's face tightened.

"You were sixteen."

"I remember."

"I remember too."

"No."

She shook her head.

"You remember the paperwork."

Her voice became softer.

"I remember my father begging."

Daniel looked away.

Lena continued.

"I remember my mother crying."

Daniel closed his eyes.

"I remember my brother asking where we were going to sleep."

He opened his eyes.

"And I remember you telling security to remove us."

Daniel whispered:

"I had a job."

Lena's expression became almost pitying.

"That's what you tell yourself."

The office was locked.

Daniel entered a code.

The door opened.

Mara followed.

Lena remained outside.

Daniel looked back.

"You coming?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I know what's in there."

Daniel stared at her.

"You don't."

She smiled.

"I know enough."

The door shut.

Daniel and Mara stood alone.

The office smelled like dust, old paper, and stale coffee.

Daniel walked to a filing cabinet.

He entered another code.

The drawer opened.

Inside were folders.

Hundreds.

Maybe thousands.

Mara stared.

"You kept all this?"

Daniel nodded.

"Why?"

"Insurance."

"Against who?"

"Everyone."

She pulled out a folder.

"What is this?"

"Don't."

She opened it.

Inside were photographs.

Contracts.

Bank statements.

Names.

Dates.

Numbers.

Mara looked up.

"These are people."

"Yes."

"You tracked them?"

"I tracked deals."

"You tracked people."

Daniel took the folder.

He opened another drawer.

More files.

Different names.

Different companies.

Different cities.

The same handwriting.

Daniel's.

Mara looked at him.

"How many?"

"I don't know."

"You said that before."

"Because it's true."

"No."

She stepped closer.

"You're avoiding the number."

Daniel looked at the files.

"There were years when I stopped counting."

Mara picked up a folder.

The name on it was JONAH BELL.

She opened it.

Daniel grabbed her wrist.

"Don't."

She stared at him.

"Why?"

"Because you don't want to know."

"That's not your decision."

"Everything in this office is dangerous."

"So are you."

Daniel let go.

Mara opened the folder.

The first page was a photograph.

Jonah Bell.

Then a series of documents.

Employment records.

Bank transfers.

A resignation letter.

Then a handwritten note.

Daniel recognized his own handwriting.

Move him before Friday.

Mara looked at her father.

"What does that mean?"

Daniel didn't answer.

She turned the page.

Another note.

If he talks, Mercer goes down with him.

Her eyes widened.

"Mercer?"

Daniel looked away.

"Your company?"

"Yes."

"You threatened Jonah."

"No."

"This says—"

"I said move him."

"Where?"

Daniel remained silent.

Mara found another page.

A missing-person report.

Jonah Bell.

Last seen twelve years ago.

She looked at Daniel.

"He's dead."

"I don't know."

"You knew."

"I suspected."

"That's not better."

"No."

She closed the folder.

Then she saw another name.

Elias Mercer.

She reached for it.

Daniel stopped her.

"Don't."

"Why?"

"Because that's mine."

"That's exactly why I'm opening it."

She pulled it free.

The folder was thicker.

Much thicker.

Inside were documents from the eviction.

Mara read.

Her face slowly changed.

There were inspection reports.

Photographs.

Payments.

Emails.

Then one document.

A handwritten note.

Mercer won't cooperate. Increase pressure.

Below it was another sentence.

If necessary, make the building uninhabitable.

Mara stopped.

Daniel saw the paper.

He knew what came next.

The fire inspection.

The gas leak.

The emergency evacuation.

The building condemned.

He had always remembered it as a sequence of unrelated events.

Now the documents connected them.

He had been there.

He had ordered it.

Mara whispered:

"You did this."

Daniel said nothing.

"You did this."

"I didn't start the fire."

"Did you order it?"

Silence.

"Did you?"

Daniel's voice was barely audible.

"I ordered the pressure."

Mara stared at him.

"What does that mean?"

"It means I told someone to make sure the building couldn't pass inspection."

"And then?"

"I don't know."

"You knew."

Daniel turned away.

Mara began crying.

Not loudly.

That made it worse.

"You knew."

Daniel's face tightened.

"I didn't know anyone would die."

"How many?"

"I don't know."

"How many?"

"Two."

Mara covered her mouth.

"Two people died?"

"Two that I know of."

She looked at the folder.

Then back at him.

"And Elias?"

"He survived the fire."

"But he killed himself later."

Daniel nodded.

"Because of you."

Daniel closed his eyes.

"I never told him to do that."

Mara's voice broke.

"That's your defense?"

Daniel looked at her.

"No."

"Then what is?"

He had no answer.

For the first time in years, Daniel Vale had no useful sentence.

A sound came from the hallway.

Mara wiped her eyes.

"What was that?"

Daniel raised his pistol.

They listened.

Nothing.

Then:

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Three slow knocks.

Daniel looked at the office door.

"Don't open it."

The knocking came again.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Mara whispered:

"Who is it?"

No answer.

Daniel moved toward the door.

Mara grabbed him.

"Don't."

He stopped.

The knocking continued.

Then a voice spoke.

Not Elias.

Not Jonah.

A woman's voice.

Old.

Weak.

"Daniel?"

He froze.

Mara looked at him.

"You know her."

Daniel's face had gone pale.

"Yes."

"Who?"

He didn't answer.

The woman spoke again.

"Daniel, please."

He knew that voice.

He hadn't heard it in fourteen years.

Her name was Ruth Mercer.

Elias's wife.

Daniel whispered:

"She's dead."

The voice replied:

"I know."

Mara's eyes widened.

Daniel slowly lowered his gun.

The voice continued.

"That's why I'm here."

The office door handle began to turn.

Daniel stepped backward.

Mara raised her pistol.

The handle stopped.

Silence.

Then the woman whispered:

"You forgot what you promised me."

Daniel's hand began shaking.

"I never promised you anything."

A pause.

Then:

"Yes, you did."

Daniel closed his eyes.

He remembered.

A hallway.

A woman standing in front of him.

Ruth Mercer.

She had grabbed his sleeve.

She had begged him.

"Please. Just give us another week."

Daniel had said:

"I'll see what I can do."

A lie.

One of thousands.

But this one had mattered.

Because she believed him.

The voice outside the door whispered:

"You said you'd come back."

Daniel couldn't breathe.

Mara stared at him.

"Did you?"

Daniel looked at his daughter.

"No."

The dead woman answered for him.

"No."

The door suddenly slammed inward.

Mara fired.

The shot struck the figure in the chest.

The body fell backward.

Daniel stared.

Ruth Mercer lay in the hallway.

Dead.

Again.

Her eyes were open.

She wasn't moving.

Mara's gun trembled.

Daniel stepped into the hallway.

Ruth's body lay beneath the red emergency light.

Then her fingers moved.

Daniel stopped.

Her head turned.

Her eyes found him.

"You didn't come back."

Daniel whispered:

"I'm sorry."

Ruth smiled.

"No."

She raised one trembling hand.

"You aren't."

Daniel stared at her.

Ruth's fingers opened.

Something fell from her palm.

A small brass key.

It hit the concrete.

Daniel recognized it.

His old office key.

From twelve years ago.

He had given it to Ruth.

She had asked him to keep important papers for her.

Daniel had forgotten.

Ruth whispered:

"Basement."

Then she died.

For real this time.

Daniel picked up the key.

Mara looked at him.

"What is in the basement?"

Daniel stared at the key.

"I don't know."

Lena appeared at the end of the corridor.

She had heard everything.

She looked at Ruth's body.

Then at Daniel.

"Yes, you do."

Daniel turned.

"What?"

"You just don't want to remember."

The warehouse basement had been sealed since Daniel took control of the building.

Nobody was allowed down there.

He'd told everyone the floor was structurally unsafe.

That had been another lie.

The door was reinforced steel.

Daniel inserted the brass key.

It didn't turn.

He tried again.

Nothing.

Lena watched.

"Wrong key."

Daniel looked at her.

"What?"

She pointed.

"There's another lock."

Daniel crouched.

There it was.

Hidden beneath the frame.

A second keyhole.

He stared at it.

Mara whispered:

"Where's the key?"

Daniel didn't answer.

Lena reached into her pocket.

She pulled out a small brass key.

Daniel stared.

"Where did you get that?"

"My father."

She inserted it.

The lock clicked.

The door opened.

Cold air rolled up the stairs.

The smell hit them.

Paper.

Mold.

And something else.

Something metallic.

Blood.

Daniel raised his flashlight.

The basement was enormous.

Rows of shelving disappeared into darkness.

Boxes filled every wall.

Documents.

Files.

Records.

Photographs.

Names.

Mara stared.

"What is this?"

Daniel stepped down.

He didn't know.

Or he didn't want to.

Lena followed.

Daniel's flashlight moved across the nearest shelf.

A label caught the beam.

MERCER DEVELOPMENT — INTERNAL

Another.

JONAH BELL — FINANCIAL

Another.

CITY INSPECTION PAYMENTS

Another.

PROPERTY ACQUISITIONS

Another.

Then Daniel saw something that made him stop.

A shelf marked:

DECEASED

Mara whispered:

"Why would you have a file for dead people?"

Daniel didn't answer.

Lena pulled one.

The name was handwritten.

ELIAS MERCER.

She opened it.

Inside was a photograph.

Elias.

Ruth.

Caleb.

And Lena.

A family photograph.

Mara looked over her shoulder.

Then Daniel noticed something.

The photograph wasn't twelve years old.

The clothes were different.

The background was different.

And on the back was a date.

THREE WEEKS AGO.

Daniel stared.

"That's impossible."

Lena took the photograph.

Her face drained of color.

"My father."

Daniel looked at her.

"He died twelve years ago."

Lena shook her head.

"No."

She turned the photograph over.

"He died three weeks ago."

Daniel stared.

Mara whispered:

"What does that mean?"

Lena looked toward the darkness at the back of the basement.

"It means my father wasn't the first one."

A sound came from somewhere among the shelves.

A box falling.

Then footsteps.

Slow.

Measured.

Approaching.

Daniel raised his gun.

Lena raised hers.

Mara stepped backward.

The flashlight beam shook.

Someone was walking toward them.

Daniel called out:

"Who's there?"

No answer.

Another step.

Then another.

A figure emerged between the shelves.

A man.

Older.

Thin.

Wearing a dark suit.

Daniel's blood went cold.

He knew him.

He had signed the man's disappearance order fifteen years ago.

Daniel whispered his name.

"Jonah."

The man smiled.

And behind him, hundreds of files began sliding from the shelves.

One after another.

Names falling into the darkness.

Jonah looked directly at Daniel.

Then said:

"You were supposed to burn these."

Daniel couldn't move.

Jonah took another step.

"But you always did have trouble finishing the job."

He lifted a folder.

On its cover was a single name.

DANIEL VALE.

And underneath it:

DEBT OUTSTANDING.